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Case Histories

PLATE 1: Woman, Age 34

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: normal

Body shape: normal, except for slight swelling of the sides

Coating: thick, dark yellow

CASE HISTORY

This patient was in relatively good health and suffered primarily from frontal headaches, stiff neck and poor digestion. The pulse was weak, especially in the right, middle position.

DIAGNOSIS

The dark yellow, thick coating indicates retention of food in the Stomach giving rise to some Heat. The problem is confined to the Stomach as the remainder of the tongue is normal, except for the slight swelling of the sides which denotes slight Spleen Qi Deficiency.

This tongue is shown here as an example of coating with root, in contrast to plate 20, which shows a coating without root. Whenever the tongue body is nearly normal and there is a coating with root, no matter how dark or thick the coating, the condition is not serious, the prognosis is good, and the condition should be easy to cure (which was true in this case).

PLATE 2: Man, Age 65

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: red, redder on the sides

Body shape: long, slightly swollen, more on the right side

Coating: thin, yellow and wet coating in the Lung area (behind the tip)

CASE HISTORY

This patient suffered from osteoarthritis of both hips and hypertension for two years. The pulse was full, wiry, rapid and deep.

DIAGNOSIS

The red tongue body which is redder on the sides denotes the presence of Heat in the Liver, i.e., Liver Fire. The long body also indicates Heat, and the slight swelling on the right side also denotes Liver Fire. This is confirmed by the rapid and wiry pulse which suggests Interior Heat due to the Liver. The hypertension is caused, in this case, by the rising of Liver Fire. The slight swelling of the whole tongue is caused by the accumulation of Dampness from Spleen Qi Deficiency. The thin, yellow coating in the Lung area reflects the retention of Dampness and Phlegm in the Lungs for a long time; this is usually due to a past cold or flu which was not properly treated (or treated with antibiotics), leading to the accumulation of Dampness and Phlegm in the Lungs. Such patients may not be aware of any problem in the chest, but are prone to further attacks of external pathogenic factors.

PLATE 3: Woman, Age 76

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: deep red, many raised red spots

Body shape: short (contracted)

Coating: completely peeled (no coating), dry

CASE HISTORY

This patient had been suffering from Parkinson's disease for over ten years. She was very thin and her skin was dry. The pulse was extremely fine, floating and empty.

DIAGNOSIS

This is a very extreme case of Yin Deficiency of the Kidneys. The deep red tongue body, the total absence of coating, the raised red spots and the dryness all reflect a severe exhaustion of Kidney Yin with blazing Heat from Deficiency. The Yin Deficiency is also confirmed by her thinness and dry skin. A tongue such as this always points to a poor prognosis and the condition must be regarded as incurable.

PLATE 4: Man, Age 25

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: red, with points on the left side

Body shape: normal

Coating: thick, yellow, greasy and sticky

CASE HISTORY

This patient suffered from hypochondriac pain, constipation, dizziness, thirst, a bitter taste in the mouth and irritability. The pulse was full and wiry.

DIAGNOSIS

All the symptoms point to Liver Fire. This is confirmed by the tongue, since the tongue body is red and there are red points on the left side, which relates to the Liver. Since there is a coating, it is Excess Heat. Furthermore, because the coating is thick, greasy and sticky, it indicates that there is also Dampness or Phlegm affecting the Gall Bladder. We can deduce that the Gall Bladder is also affected from the presence of a thick coating which signifies a problem in a Yang Organ. This is a coating with root.

PLATE 5: Woman, Age 80

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: red

Body shape: swollen

Coating: rootless, moldy, partially peeled

CASE HISTORY

This patient suffered from rheumatism of the wrists and knees. Apart from this, she was relatively healthy.

DIAGNOSIS

This tongue clearly shows Heat and Deficiency of Stomach Yin. The swelling of the body is, in this case, due to Heat. The partially peeled coating indicates Stomach Yin Deficiency. The "moldy" coating (only slightly moldy in this patient) suggests that there is Heat in the Stomach (in this case from Stomach Yin Deficiency) which evaporates the Stomach fluids and causes them to go up to the tongue. The moldy coating looks like crumbled beancurd, cottage cheese or porridge.

Even though the tongue shows an advanced pathology of the Stomach, this patient is relatively healthy. This apparent contradiction can be explained by the age of the patient. At an advanced age the Yin usually becomes Deficient (in this case, more the Stomach Yin) and the tongue will show certain changes, while the patient is often free of symptoms.

PLATE 6: Woman, Age 65

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: pale

Body shape: swollen, with some cracks

Coating: thin, white and dry

CASE HISTORY

This patient suffered from chronic asthma, with particular difficulty in inhalation, for over thirty years. She had considerable mucus in the chest which was occasionally coughed up. The mucus was white and watery. The pulse was weak, especially in the proximal position.

DIAGNOSIS

The pale and swollen tongue body denotes a Deficiency of Spleen Yang with accumulation of Dampness. Kidney Yang is also Deficient as shown by the weakness of the pulse at the proximal position. The Deficiency of Kidney Yang can also be deduced from the long duration of the condition and the nature of the problem. Any long-standing Deficiency of the Spleen can, over time, lead to a Deficiency of the Kidneys. In the case of very chronic asthma in an elderly person in particular, the Kidneys are almost certain to be affected. This is also confirmed by the fact that inhalation is more difficult than exhalation: this is due to the impairment of the Kidneys' function of grasping the Qi.

The patient's tongue coating is dry and has some cracks which reflects the long-standing Deficiency of Yang. When Yang Qi is very Deficient over a long period of time, it cannot move the fluids which then do not reach the tongue; hence the dry and slightly cracked tongue body. A pale and dry tongue can also indicate Blood Deficiency. How do we know in this case that it is due to Yang Deficiency? Because the tongue body is quite swollen which denotes accumulation of Dampness caused by Yang Deficiency of the Spleen. In the case of Blood Deficiency the tongue body would either be thin or of normal size.

PLATE 7: Man, Age 67

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: dark red, redder on the sides

Body shape: thin, sides slightly swollen, crack in the center to the tip, slightly swollen in the chest area (between the tip and center all across the tongue), slightly flaccid

Coating: thin and white

CASE HISTORY

This patient suffered from chronic lower back pain and tinnitus. The pulse was full, rapid and wiry.

DIAGNOSIS

The dark red tongue body indicates Heat. The sides are redder and slightly swollen: this shows that the Heat is in the Liver. This is confirmed by the rapid and wiry pulse. There is a crack in the center to the tip which indicates that Liver Fire has been transmitted to the Heart, giving rise to Heart Fire. The body is thin because the Heat has begun to injure and dry up the body fluids, but this has

not yet resulted in Yin Deficiency. The slight swelling between the tip and the center denotes stagnation of Qi in the chest (presumably from emotional problems, as there is also Heart Fire). The swelling in this area causes the crack to deviate which shows that the stagnation of Qi in the chest has constricted the Heart.

PLATE 8: Man, Age 62

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: normal

Body shape: swollen on the sides, crack in the center to the tip with swelling on both sides

Coating: sticky and dirty with prickles inside the central crack

CASE HISTORY

This patient suffered from epigastric pain, indigestion and rheumatic pain in the wrists and knees. The pulse was deep and weak, except for the Heart pulse which was overflowing but empty.

DIAGNOSIS

In this case the body shape and coating are primary in relation to the body color which does not show pathological changes. The swelling of the sides indicates a long-standing Deficiency of Spleen Qi which is unable to transform and transport the fluids. The central crack down to the tip shows a constitutional weakness of the heart, and the swelling around it suggests that the Heart Qi has been further disrupted by emotional trauma. The swelling on either side of the central crack reflects that the heart is enlarged. This is also borne out by the overflowing and empty Heart pulse which indicates that the Heart Qi is weak (hence the empty pulse) and that the patient is driving himself too hard and has some emotional problems (hence the overflowing pulse).

The dirty coating and prickles inside the central crack show that there has been retention of food in the Stomach for a long time which has now been transformed into Stomach Phlegm and Fire. The Phlegm is reflected in the stickiness of the coating.

In sum, both the Stomach and Spleen have been Deficient for a long time which has led to the accumulation of Dampness and the formation of Phlegm and Fire in the Stomach. Eventually, the Phlegm and Fire could produce mental symptoms, "misting" the Spirit. This is shown by the presence of prickles inside the central crack which is related to the Heart.

PLATE 9: Woman, Age 51

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: pale

Body shape: swollen

Coating: wet

CASE HISTORY

This patient suffered from persistent shaking of the head which started two years previously. She also had slight palpitations, insomnia and frequent urination, also at night. The pulse was weak and deep. The Western medical diagnosis for her condition was Parkinson's disease.

DIAGNOSIS

The pale tongue body indicates Deficiency of Yang which is confirmed by the swelling of the body and the wetness of the coating. In this case the Deficient Yang Qi has led to the accumulation of Dampness, as shown by the swollen and wet tongue body. The Deficiency of Yang is of the Spleen and Kidneys, judging by the pulse and the frequent urination. The Deficiency of Spleen Yang has also led to the Spleen being unable to generate enough Blood, and therefore to Blood Deficiency. This is manifested by the palpitations and insomnia. The Deficiency of Blood, in turn, has led to a rising of Liver Wind which is the cause of the shaking. It is important to note that this is Deficiency Wind because it arises from Deficiency of Blood. In this case, judging by the pulse and tongue, the condition is primarily one of Deficiency and therefore calls for tonification of the Spleen and Kidneys.

PLATE 10: Girl, Age 10

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: normal, with red points on the right side

Body shape: normal

Coating: thin white coating on the right side

CASE HISTORY

This child was suffering at the time from an acute upper respiratory tract infection with sore throat and pain in one ear.

DIAGNOSIS

This tongue is a clear example of external attack of Wind Heat at the Lesser Yang stage. In the Lesser Yang syndrome there is typically a thin white coating on the right side only, as in this case. In addition, there are also red points on the right side which indicate that the Heat is beginning to proceed into the Interior.

PLATE 11: Man, Age 64

TONGUE SIGNS

Body color: red, shiny anteriorly

Body shape: slightly stiff and deviated, deep crack in the center to the tip, right side slightly swollen

Coating: thin, slightly dry and dirty, no coating in the center